Aleksei Opacic

Contact

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Research interests

Human Capital, Labor Markets and Careers, Economic Sociology, Inequality, Quantitative and Computational Methods

Education

Harvard University

Ph.D. Sociology (expected 2027)

Dissertation: "College-to-Work(place) Linkages and the Returns to Education"

Committee: Xiang Zhou, Christina Ciocca Eller, Chris Winship, Nathan Wilmers (MIT Sloan)

Exams: Stratification (Distinction), Demography (Distinction), Organizations, Gender

A.M. Statistics (2024)

University of Oxford

M.Sc. Sociology (2019), *Distinction (Ranked First)*

University of Cambridge

B.A. Social and Political Science (2018), *Starred First Class (Ranked First)*

Publications

Opacic, Aleksei (2026). "Where Do the Returns to Schooling Come From? Educational Transitions and Labor Market Payoffs." Accepted at *Annals of Applied Statistics*.

- Clifford C. Clogg Graduate Student Paper Award, Methodology Section, American Sociological Association
- Outstanding Graduate Student Paper Award, Mathematical Sociology Section, American Sociological Association

Opacic, Aleksei, Lai Wei, and Xiang Zhou (2026). "Disparity Analysis: A Tale of Two Approaches." *Journal of the Royal Statistical Society Series A: Statistics in Society*, 189, 805–833.

Bloome, Deirdre, and **Aleksei Opacic** (2024). "Absolute Income Mobility Obscures Marginalized Children's Disadvantages." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 121 (25).

Revise & Resubmit

"Who Gets to Use Their College Skills? Skill-Job Alignment and Earnings Inequality Among College Graduates." Revise & Resubmit at *American Sociological Review*.

- Geoffrey Tootell Award, Mathematical Sociology Section, American Sociological Association

"From Flagship to Firm: Employer Sorting and the Organizational Returns to College." Revise & Resubmit at *American Journal of Sociology*.

- Ronald Burt Student Paper Award, Economic Sociology Section, Honorable Mention, American Sociological Association

Under review

"Marginal Interventional Effects" (with Xiang Zhou). Resubmitted to *Statistical Science*.

"Assumption Smuggling in Tests of Causal Mechanisms" (with Matthew Blackwell and Ruofan Ma).

Works in progress

"Matchmakers and Gatekeepers: AI Recommendations and Racial Disparities in Hiring."

"Explaining Gradational Inequalities" (with Lai Wei and Xiang Zhou).

Book chapters	Evans, Geoffrey, and **Aleksei Opacic** (2022). "How Social Class Influences Political Choices." *The Cambridge Handbook of Political Psychology*, eds. Danny Osborne and Chris G. Sibley. Cambridge University Press. pp. 382–398.
Software	"disparity: Estimation of Descriptive and Prescriptive Disparity Estimands" (with Lai Wei and Xiang Zhou). github.com/alekseiopacic/disparity
Other writing	"Education to Workforce Pathways Diagnostic Toolkit: Analysis Narrative" (2024, with Atticus Bolyard, Sue Dynarski, Jon Fullerton, Miriam Greenberg, Julia Lubner, Eric Taylor, and Rachel Worsham). "Education to Workforce Pathways Diagnostic Toolkit: Technical Guide" (2024, with Atticus Bolyard, Sue Dynarski, Jon Fullerton, Miriam Greenberg, Julia Lubner, Eric Taylor, and Rachel Worsham).
Courses taught	*Harvard University* Teaching Fellow, Intermediate Quantitative Methods (2022–3). *Certificate of Distinction in Teaching* Teaching Fellow, Advanced Quantitative Methods (2025).
Research awards and fellowships	Geoffrey Tootell Outstanding Dissertation-in-Progress Award, ASA Mathematical Sociology Section (2026, $5,000) IQSS Research Grant (2025, $2,000) James M. and Cathleen D. Stone Research Grant (2025, $5,000) IQSS Research Grant (2024, $3,000) Russell Sage Foundation Dissertation Research Grant (2024, $10,000) Center for American Political Studies Seed Grant, Harvard University (2024, $1,000) Jeanne Humphrey Block Dissertation Award, Harvard University (2024, $2,500) Population Center Dissertation Research Award, Harvard University (2024, $2,000) Linda G. Hammett Ory Fellowship, Harvard Graduate School of Education (2023, $15,000) Kennedy Scholarship, Harvard University (2020, $20,000) The A.H. Halsey Prize, University of Oxford (2019) The Polity Prize, The Pollard Memorial Prize, and King's College Scholarship, University of Cambridge (2018)
Invited talks	Harvard Data Science Initiative (HDSI), Harvard University (2026) Quantitative Social Science Colloquium, Dartmouth College (2026) Education Data Science Seminar, Stanford University (2025) Economic Sociology Seminar, Harvard University/MIT (2025) Applied Statistics Workshop, Harvard University (2024) Inequality Workshop, Stanford University (2023) Social Demography Seminar, Harvard University (2022)
Selected conference presentations	"Who Gets to Use Their College Skills? Skill-Job Alignment and Earnings Inequality Among College Graduates." Annual Meeting of the Population Association of America, St. Louis, MO (April 2026). "From Flagship to Firm: Employer Sorting and the Organizational Returns to College." Annual Meeting of the American Sociological Association, Chicago, IL (August 2025). "Assumption Smuggling in Tests of Causal Mechanisms" (with Matthew Blackwell and Ruofan Ma). Annual Meeting of the American Political Science Association, Philadelphia, PA (August 2024).

"Absolute Income Mobility Obscures Marginalized Children's Disadvantages" (with Deirdre Bloome). Annual Meeting of the American Sociological Association, Montreal, CA (August 2024).

"Cumulative Disadvantage and the BA Attainment Gap." Annual Meeting of the American Sociological Association, Montreal, CA (August 2024).

"Absolute Income Mobility Obscures Marginalized Children's Disadvantages" (with Deirdre Bloome). Annual Meeting of the Population Association of America, Columbus, OH (April 2024).

"Path-Specific Effects under Monotonic Mediation." Annual Meeting of the Population Association of America, Columbus (April 2024).

"Path-Specific Effects under Monotonic Mediation." Annual Meeting of the American Sociological Association, Philadelphia, PA (August 2023).

"Disparity Analysis: A Tale of Two Approaches" (with Lai Wei and Xiang Zhou). Annual Meeting of the International Sociological Association, Melbourne, Australia (June 2023, Declined).

"Does Higher Education Tend Towards Egalitarianism? Evidence from a Population Transitions Model." Annual Meeting of the Population Association of America, New Orleans, LA (April 2023).

"An Interventional Approach to Primary and Secondary Effects in Intergenerational Mobility." Annual Meeting of the American Sociological Association, Los Angeles, CA (August 2022).

"Marginal Interventional Effects" (with Xiang Zhou). Annual Meeting of the American Sociological Association, Los Angeles, CA (August 2022).

Experience

Netflix — Experimentation & Causal Inference Researcher (2025), Los Gatos, CA

Institute for Global Change — Researcher (2019–2020), London, UK

Service

- Sociology Tenure-Track Faculty Search Committee, Harvard University (2024–2025)
- Sociology Graduate Admissions Committee, Harvard University (2021–2022)
- *Invited Reviewer:* American Journal of Sociology, American Sociological Review, Social Forces, Sociology of Education, Political Behavior, Research in Social Stratification and Mobility, Sociological Methods and Research

Affiliations

American Sociological Association; Academy of Management; Population Association of America; American Statistical Association; Institute for Quantitative Social Science, Harvard; Center for Population and Development Studies, Harvard School of Public Health; EdRedesign, Harvard Graduate School of Education

References

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